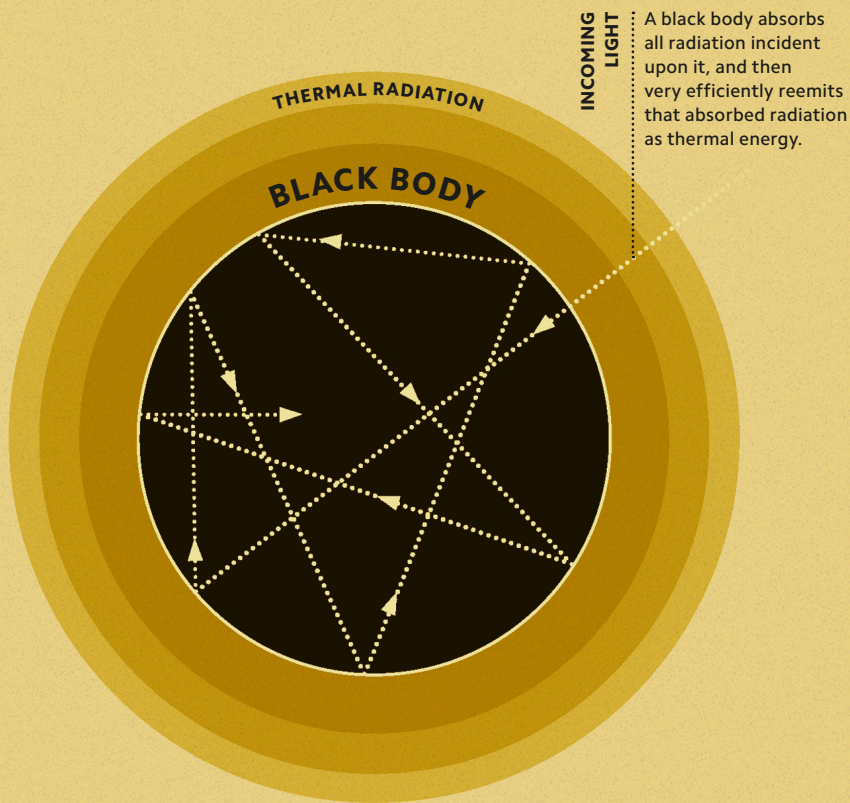




IDEAL BODIES

In order to understand how objects emit electromagnetic radiation when they are heated, scientists use an idealized object called a "black body." All but the coldest objects emit some form of radiation, but because most will also reflect radiation from their surroundings, it can be hard to measure how much radiation is actually being released. A black body has a pitch-black, completely nonreflective surface whose radiation is dependent only on its temperature.